

film review

Comfort of Cliches

MUMBAI MERI JAAN

Rating: ★★☆☆☆
Director: Nishikant Kamat
Starring: R. Madhavan,
Soha Ali Khan, Paresh
Rawal

Warning. This is the kind of movie that can either set every self-respecting cynic's teeth on edge with its political correctness or have every soft touch with a marshmallow heart sniffing into their tissues. It all depends on how comfortable you are with seeing every cliché about India being reaffirmed in this film inspired by Mumbai's July 11, 2006 train blasts. So yes, the inflammatory Hindu fanatic ends up sharing a chat and chai with the Muslim. Yes, the rookie policeman who thinks he's in an art film ends up understanding his world-weary veteran partner. And yes, the hard-bitten TV journalist, who unthinkingly shoves a microphone into the face of grieving victims for a reaction to "aapko kaisa mehsoos ho raha hai", is made to swap places. But there is a raw muscularity in Nishikant Kamat's di-



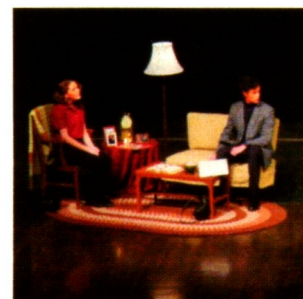
SPLIT LIVES: A still from *Mumbai Meri Jaan*

rection, and an unswerving grasp on the five stories in his non-linear, *Babel*-inspired narrative. A body flies out of a suburban train compartment, is hit by an oncoming train, and then leaps out of the screen. You hear yourself gasp. Then again, the cool professional newswoman falters while telling her own sob story, breaking down into the camera she's made it her business to befriend. You hear yourself gasp again. Mumbai has had its share of balladeers, some who have romanticised its mean streets and others who have made a fortune off its hedonistic excesses. In *Mumbai Meri Jaan*, these two impulses collide and

Kamat's camera is there to capture it. The immigrant *thelawala* who sets off a series of bomb scares in malls because he is thrown out of one for daring to sample the wares in a fancy store and the smart IT whiz who is tempted by the idea of living in California are two sides of a city that celebrates desi tycoons and dabbawalas. Kamat, who made the Marathi *Dombivli Fast* and the Tamil *Evano Oruvan*, is a filmmaker with a sure touch. He is not racing against time to tell each tale, waiting for each to have its own poignant sign-off. In a world of jump cuts and handycams, such unhurried poise is to be admired. **by Kaveree Bamzai**

theatre Back to the Past

BANGALORE The city's Centre for Film and Drama will be staging Anton Chekhov's immortal work *The Cherry Orchard* under the name of *City of Gardens*. Being directed by Jisha Menon, assistant professor of English at the University of British Columbia, Vancouver, the play is a re-imagining of its original. While the classic realist play captures the moment of transition from feudal landed aristocracy to a robust bourgeoisie at the turn of the century in Russia, the *City of Gardens*



The Cherry Orchard

explores a similar transition of Bangalore from a sleepy cantonment to a vibrant global city. "The play deals with the loss of home and charts the emotional impact of the refashioning of the city upon its dwellers, both old and new. It also addresses a range of philosophical and social questions about belonging, home, identity and considers how these changes have reconfigured the relationship between the city and its citizens," says Menon. Originally written as a comedy with satire and farce, it was in Stanislavski's version when it was played as a tragedy. It is said that Chekhov loved trees and his theatre often equalled his feeling for nature along with his characters, who were often symbolic of them. See it from September 4 to 6 at Ranga Shankara and on September 12 at Grasshopper.

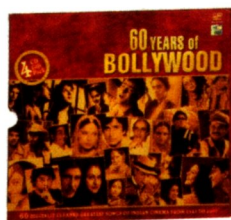
by Nirmala Ravindran

music review Reliving Melodies

60 YEARS OF BOLLYWOOD

Our film industry weaves its magic through its music, its glamorous heroines courting romantic heroes in gorgeous locales. In the past 60 years, Bollywood has grown to mythical proportions with every decade's numerous super hits and unforget-

table melodies. This selection, handpicked by experts, brings you the chart toppers. Each year has been represented with one



Sa Re Ga Ma
Rs 500

hit song. Don't miss the classic *Afsana likh rahin hoon* by Uma Devi in *Dard* or the modern *Maula mere maula* by Roop Kumar Rathod in *Anwar*. It has all the ingredients of pathos like *Ehsaan tere hoga mujh par* in *Junglee* to the fun-filled *Haal kaisa hai janab ka* from *Chalti Ka Naam Gaadi* or the modern *Behege honth tere* from *Murder*. A collector's item.

by S. Sahaya Ranjit